



Gukesh has had a much better year. His performance was phenomenal on the top board for India in the Budapest Chess Olympiad. Ding has, of course, been in a crisis for a while, and I think this year he was trying to snap out of it but just hasn't managed. Having said that, the World Championship is quite famous for people who have been in red-hot form in other events but then not being able to generate the same dynamic in the actual match.

Gukesh will have to fight for every point. He should be confident with his play but should not expect that the resistance will be lower. Ding will have a chance to motivate himself, and he showed in his match against

Tough ask: According to the author, Gukesh will "have to fight for every point" against Ding Liren in the World Championship final. MARK LIVSHITZ/FIDE & THE HINDU PHOTO LIBRARY

Nepomniachtchi that he is quite tenacious. So I don't think that the past results are themselves very indicative of anything.

Whether Ding will be able to recover from the slump of form is one of the question marks. I don't know what to expect. He might try to settle in early in the match. I think it may be more appropriate for him to start fighting from Game 1 because of the short runway to get into the match.



I believe that a rivalry between India and China will be fascinating to watch. And this is a historic match, as Gukesh is the world's youngest challenger of all time.